MAINCRAFTS TECHNOLOGY | CYBERSECURITY INTERNSHIP PROGRAM

Threat Intelligence Report

Latest Cybersecurity Threats (2024–2025) and Defense Measures

TASK	Task-1: Threat Report (Awareness & Research Project)
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1. Introduction to Cybersecurity

1.1 What is cybersecurity?

Cybersecurity is the practice of protecting computers, networks, applications and data from unauthorized access, theft, damage and disruption. It is usually explained through the **CIA triad**: **Confidentiality** (only the right people can see information), **Integrity** (information is accurate and has not been tampered with) and **Availability** (systems and data work when they are needed). Every threat in this report attacks at least one of the three.

1.2 Why it matters for individuals and businesses

For individuals, phones, bank accounts, email, photos and health records are now the keys to daily life. When they are compromised the result can be stolen money, identity theft, harassment or years of fraud attempts using leaked data.

For businesses, a single incident can stop operations, expose customer data, trigger fines under privacy and sector regulations, and damage trust that took years to build. Because organizations depend on cloud services, remote access, connected devices and third-party vendors, an attacker no longer needs to defeat a company directly. A weakness in a supplier, a forgotten device or one employee's account can be enough.

1.3 Current relevance

Cybercrime is growing in both volume and cost, and artificial intelligence is making attacks faster and more convincing:

- **Rising crime.** The FBI's Internet Crime Complaint Center (IC3) received more than one million complaints in 2025 for the first time, with **US$20.9 billion** in reported losses, up 26% from US$16.6 billion in 2024 [1]. The FBI also reported AI-related complaints separately for the first time: 22,364 complaints and about US$893 million in losses [1].
- **Rising cost of breaches.** IBM's 2026 report puts the global average cost of a data breach at a record **US$4.99 million** (US$11.5 million in the United States), and found that about one in four malicious breaches is now AI-enabled, costing roughly US$1 million more than average [3][4].
- **Changing attack methods.** In Verizon's 2026 Data Breach Investigations Report, exploitation of software vulnerabilities (31%) overtook stolen credentials (13%) as the most common way into a breach for the first time, and ransomware appeared in 48% of breaches [5][6][7].

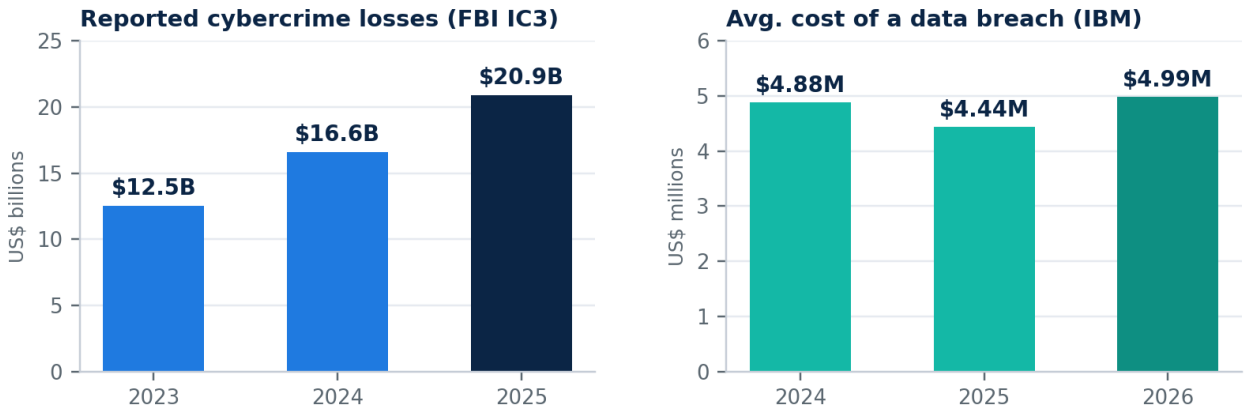


Figure 1. Reported cybercrime losses (FBI IC3, 2023–2025) and the global average cost of a data breach (IBM, 2024–2026). Sources: [1][2][3].

1.4 Scope and method

This report covers five major threats that were active in 2024–2025. Each is analyzed in the same way: what it is, how it harms individuals and organizations, a real-world case study, and practical preventive measures. Case studies were cross-checked against several public sources (government advisories, incident-response firms and major news outlets). Where a figure comes from press reporting or an attacker's own claim, the text says so (for example, “reportedly”). Numbered references in square brackets are listed in the References section.

2. Threat Landscape Overview

The table summarizes the five threats analyzed in this report. Risk levels are the author's qualitative assessment, based on how widespread each threat is and how severe the harm was in the case study.

#	Threat	What it is	Headline 2024–25 case	Risk
1	**AI-Powered Phishing & Deepfakes**	AI makes impersonation by email, voice and video cheap, personal and convincing.	Arup deepfake video-call fraud (US$25.6M)	**High**
2	**Ransomware-as-a-Service (RaaS)**	Criminals rent ready-made ransomware and split the profits with its developers.	Change Healthcare attack (about 190M people affected)	**Critical**
3	**Cloud Security Misconfigurations**	Weak access settings or missing MFA leave cloud and SaaS data exposed.	Snowflake customer data thefts (about 165 organizations)	**High**
4	**IoT Vulnerabilities**	Unpatched, default-password devices are hijacked into botnets or used as footholds.	Raptor Train botnet (260,000+ devices)	**High**
5	**Zero-Day Exploits**	Flaws with no patch yet are exploited before defenders can react.	Ivanti Connect Secure zero-days (2024); SharePoint “ToolShell” (2025)	**Critical**

Case studies at a glance

US$25.6M
lost in one deepfake video call
ARUP, 2024

~190M
people's data stolen in one attack
CHANGE HEALTHCARE, 2024

165
customer environments accessed
SNOWFLAKE CUSTOMERS, 2024

260,000+
devices in one state-linked botnet
RAPTOR TRAIN, 2024

2
zero-days chained into one exploit
IVANTI, 2024

3. Threat Analysis

Each threat below follows the same structure: overview, impact analysis, a real-world case study and preventive measures.

3.1 AI-Powered Phishing and Deepfake Attacks

RISK LEVEL	MAIN TARGET	ATTACKER'S GOAL
HIGH	People and finance teams	Fraud and credential theft

Phishing tricks a person into revealing credentials, installing malware or sending money. Generative AI has made it far more effective: attackers can write flawless, personalized messages in any language, clone a voice from a short audio clip and generate realistic video of real executives. The old warning signs, such as typos and awkward phrasing, are disappearing. The FBI listed phishing and spoofing as the most reported crime type in 2025 (191,561 complaints) [1], and IBM found phishing was still the leading way attackers got in [4].

Impact on individuals	Impact on organizations
• Stolen passwords and one-time codes lead to account takeover of email, banking and social media. • Voice-clone and deepfake scams (“your relative needs money now”) cause direct loss. In 2024, people over 60 reported the highest losses of any age group, about US$4.9 billion [2]. • Stolen identity details are reused for loans, tax fraud and more phishing.	• Business email compromise and fake-executive requests trigger fraudulent wire transfers; BEC losses reported to the FBI were US$2.77 billion in 2024 [2]. • Phished staff credentials are a common first step toward ransomware and data theft. • Financial loss, regulatory scrutiny and loss of customer trust.

REAL-WORLD CASE STUDY

Arup deepfake video-call fraud, Hong Kong (2024)

In January 2024 a finance employee at the Hong Kong office of Arup, the British engineering firm behind landmarks such as the Sydney Opera House, joined a video call with what appeared to be the company's CFO and several colleagues. Every other participant was an AI-generated deepfake built from publicly available video and audio. Following their instructions, the employee made 15 transfers totalling HK$200 million (about US$25.6 million) to five bank accounts. Hong Kong police described the case in February 2024, and Arup confirmed in May 2024 that it was the victim [8][9].

Key lesson: *No system was hacked. The attack targeted human trust, and seeing and hearing a familiar face is no longer proof of identity.*

Preventive measures

1. **Verify out of band.** Confirm payment and credential requests through a second, trusted channel (such as a call to a known number) and require two approvers for large transfers.
2. **Phishing-resistant MFA.** Passkeys or FIDO2 security keys make stolen passwords and codes far less useful to an attacker.
3. **Security awareness training.** Include deepfake and voice-clone scenarios and regular phishing simulations, and make reporting suspicious messages easy and blame-free.
4. **Email protection.** Enforce SPF, DKIM and DMARC and use filtering to block spoofed senders and malicious links.

3.2 Ransomware-as-a-Service (RaaS)

RISK LEVEL	MAIN TARGET	ATTACKER'S GOAL
CRITICAL	Organizations, especially healthcare	Extortion for payment

Ransomware encrypts an organization's files and demands payment for the key. Most modern gangs also steal data first and threaten to publish it ("double extortion"). In the **Ransomware-as-a-Service** model, a core group builds the malware and the payment and leak-site infrastructure, then rents it to "affiliates" who break into victims and share the ransom with the developers. This lowers the skill needed to attack and has turned ransomware into an industry. Verizon's 2026 report found ransomware in 48% of breaches, up from 44% a year earlier, although 69% of victims reportedly refused to pay [7].

Impact on individuals	Impact on organizations
• Personal, financial and medical records are stolen and leaked, enabling identity theft and fraud. • Essential services are disrupted: delayed prescriptions, appointments and payments. • Long-term anxiety and risk when health data or ID numbers are published or sold.	• Operations stop when systems are encrypted or shut down for safety; downtime often costs more than the ransom itself. • Ransom, recovery, legal and notification costs, with no guarantee that paying deletes the stolen data. • Regulatory exposure (health-privacy and data-protection laws), lawsuits and lasting reputation damage.

REAL-WORLD CASE STUDY

Change Healthcare ransomware attack, United States (2024)

On 21 February 2024, billing and claims systems at Change Healthcare, a UnitedHealth Group company that processes a very large share of US healthcare payments, went offline after the company shut down its network to isolate intruders. The attack was carried out by an affiliate of the ALPHV/BlackCat RaaS gang. Pharmacies and medical practices across the US struggled to process claims for weeks. UnitedHealth confirmed it paid a ransom, reportedly about US$22 million. ALPHV's leaders then vanished without paying the affiliate, who moved to a new group, RansomHub, and demanded a second ransom [10].

In January 2025 the company confirmed that about **190 million people** were affected, the largest healthcare data breach in US history [10][11]. UnitedHealth reported roughly US$1.1 billion in attack-related costs in the second quarter of 2024 alone [11]. Its CEO later told Congress that the attackers got in using a single compromised password on an account that had no multi-factor authentication [10].

Key lesson: *One account without MFA exposed a company that handles data on a large share of Americans, and paying the ransom did not end the extortion.*

Preventive measures

1. **MFA wherever it matters.** Require it for all remote access, email and administrator accounts.
2. **Offline, tested backups and an incident response plan.** Follow the 3-2-1 rule (three copies, two media types, one offline or immutable) and rehearse recovery before an attack, not during one.
3. **Network segmentation and endpoint detection (EDR).** Limit lateral movement so one compromised system does not become a network-wide outage, and alert on early signs such as mass file access or encryption.

3.3 Cloud Security Misconfigurations

RISK LEVEL	MAIN TARGET	ATTACKER'S GOAL
HIGH	Cloud and SaaS accounts	Data theft and extortion

Cloud providers such as AWS, Microsoft Azure and Google Cloud, and SaaS platforms such as Snowflake, work on a **shared responsibility model**: the provider secures the underlying infrastructure, while the customer must configure access, identities and data correctly. Typical mistakes include publicly exposed storage buckets, over-permissive roles, accounts without MFA, unrestricted network access and unrotated keys. These are rarely exotic. Verizon found that for half of all findings about weak passwords and permission misconfigurations, it took close to eight months to resolve them [6].

Impact on individuals	Impact on organizations
• Names, addresses, call records or financial details exposed in one leak can fuel phishing, SIM-swap and identity fraud for years. • People rarely know which cloud their data sits in, so they cannot protect it themselves.	• Mass data theft and extortion, often with no malware on the victim's own network. • Regulatory fines, breach-notification costs and class-action lawsuits. • Loss of customer trust, especially for data-driven services.

REAL-WORLD CASE STUDY

Snowflake customer data thefts (2024)

Between April and mid-2024, a financially motivated group tracked by Google's Mandiant as UNC5537 accessed about 165 Snowflake customer environments, stole large volumes of records, advertised the data for sale and tried to extort victims. Ticketmaster and Santander were among the reported victims. Investigators concluded that Snowflake's own platform was not breached. Instead, the attackers used valid customer credentials harvested by infostealer malware (some stolen as far back as 2020) on accounts that did not require MFA. Mandiant assessed that MFA would have prevented the compromise [12][13].

Key lesson: *This was not a software flaw. It was a customer-side identity and configuration gap: no MFA, no network allow-listing and credentials that stayed valid for years.*

Preventive measures

1. **Enforce MFA and network allow-lists** on every cloud and SaaS account, and give each role only the permissions it needs (least privilege).
2. **Scan configurations continuously.** Use cloud security posture management (CSPM) or provider-native tools to find public storage and risky permissions early.
3. **Rotate credentials and monitor access.** Rotate keys and passwords, remove unused accounts and alert on unusual bulk data exports.
4. **Adopt Zero Trust.** “Never trust, always verify”: check identity, device and context on every request instead of trusting anything inside the network.

3.4 IoT Vulnerabilities

RISK LEVEL	MAIN TARGET	ATTACKER'S GOAL
HIGH	Consumer and enterprise devices	Botnets, espionage, footholds

The Internet of Things covers any connected device that is not a traditional computer: IP cameras, routers, DVRs, network storage, smart TVs, printers, and medical or industrial sensors. Many ship with default passwords, get few firmware updates and cannot run security software, yet they stay online for years. Attackers recruit them into botnets for DDoS attacks and traffic relaying, spy through cameras and microphones, or use them as a hidden foothold in a home or corporate network.

Impact on individuals	Impact on organizations
• Hacked cameras and baby monitors expose private life; a compromised router lets attackers intercept traffic and steal credentials. • A hijacked device slows the home network and can be used to attack others, with the owner's IP address taking the blame.	• Unmanaged devices give attackers an entry point into internal networks and are hard to inventory and patch. • Botnets cause DDoS outages and let attackers hide espionage traffic behind ordinary-looking devices. • In industrial and healthcare settings, compromised devices can interrupt physical operations.

REAL-WORLD CASE STUDY

Raptor Train botnet (2024)

In September 2024 the FBI and US Department of Justice announced a court-authorized operation against Raptor Train, a botnet that security researchers at Lumen's Black Lotus Labs had tracked for about four years. The US government attributed it to Flax Typhoon, a Chinese state-sponsored group operating through a Beijing company, Integrity Technology Group. As of June 2024 it had compromised more than **260,000 devices**, predominantly in the US: small-office and home routers, IP cameras, video recorders and network storage. The malware was a variant of the infamous Mirai botnet code, and the network was used to disguise intrusions and data theft against targeted organizations. With court approval, the FBI sent commands that removed the malware from infected devices [14][15][16].

Key lesson: *Neglected consumer-grade devices can become infrastructure for a nation-state, and their owners would probably never notice.*

Preventive measures

1. **Change default credentials and disable unneeded features.** Set unique strong passwords and turn off remote administration and UPnP unless they are required.
2. **Update firmware and retire end-of-life devices.** Prefer vendors that publish regular security updates, and replace hardware that no longer receives them.
3. **Segment and monitor.** Put IoT devices on a separate VLAN or guest network so a compromised camera cannot reach laptops, servers or backups, and use IDS/IPS to flag unusual outbound connections.

3.5 Zero-Day Exploits

RISK LEVEL	MAIN TARGET	ATTACKER'S GOAL
CRITICAL	Internet-facing software	Initial access and espionage

A zero-day is a vulnerability that is unknown to the vendor, or has no patch yet, when attackers start exploiting it. Defenders have had “zero days” to prepare. Attackers favor internet-facing “edge” systems such as VPN gateways, firewalls, file-transfer tools and collaboration servers, because a single flaw can give remote access to an entire network. The wider picture is just as serious: in Verizon's 2026 report, exploitation of vulnerabilities (31%) overtook stolen credentials (13%) as the leading way into a breach for the first time, and the time between disclosure and exploitation keeps shrinking [5][6].

Impact on individuals	Impact on organizations
• Often indirect: data held by a compromised organization (an employer, bank or clinic) is stolen. • Directly, zero-days in browsers, phones and operating systems can enable spyware or account takeover with little or no user action.	• Attackers gain remote code execution before any patch exists and can stay hidden for weeks or months. • Emergency shutdowns, forensic investigations and rebuilds of affected appliances. • Data theft, ransomware follow-on attacks and compliance consequences when breach notification is required.

REAL-WORLD CASE STUDY

Ivanti Connect Secure zero-days (2024), and SharePoint “ToolShell” (2025)

On 10 January 2024 Ivanti disclosed two zero-day flaws in its Connect Secure and Policy Secure VPN gateways: an authentication bypass (CVE-2023-46805) and a command injection (CVE-2024-21887). Chained together, they let an attacker run commands on the appliance without logging in. Exploitation began with at least one suspected nation-state actor and then spread to multiple threat actors [18]. On 19 January CISA issued Emergency Directive 24-01, its first of 2024, ordering US federal civilian agencies to apply Ivanti's mitigations immediately [17]. Patches for many versions only followed in the weeks after, so organizations relied on temporary mitigations in the meantime.

The pattern repeated in July 2025 with Microsoft SharePoint's “ToolShell” flaw (CVE-2025-53770). It was exploited against on-premises servers from about 18 July, was added to CISA's Known Exploited Vulnerabilities catalog on 20 July, and its first attack waves, aimed at high-value targets, were linked to China [19][20].

Key lesson: *When no patch exists, defense means reducing exposure and limiting damage: restrict who can reach management interfaces, segment networks and monitor for compromise.*

Preventive measures

1. **Disciplined patch management.** Keep an asset inventory, prioritize internet-facing systems and vulnerabilities listed in CISA's KEV catalog, and set deadlines measured in days, not months.
2. **Zero Trust and segmentation.** Assume any device can be compromised: restrict access, segment networks and never expose admin interfaces directly to the internet.
3. **Layered detection.** Use firewalls with IDS/IPS (including virtual patching), EDR and centralized logging, and hunt for signs of compromise after every major advisory.

4. Putting It Together: Defense in Depth

Although the threats differ, the same handful of controls keep appearing. The matrix shows how strongly each control reduces risk for each threat (author's qualitative assessment based on the case studies). No single control is enough, which is why security teams layer several of them.

Control	AI phishing	RaaS	Cloud misconfig.	IoT	Zero-day
MFA (phishing-resistant)	**Key**	**Key**	**Key**	-	-
Patch management	-	Helps	-	**Key**	**Key**
Zero Trust and segmentation	Helps	**Key**	**Key**	**Key**	**Key**
Security awareness training	**Key**	Helps	-	Helps	-
Backups and incident response plan	Helps	**Key**	Helps	-	Helps
Monitoring (IDS/IPS, EDR, logs)	Helps	**Key**	**Key**	Helps	**Key**

Key = primary control for this threat; **Helps** = reduces impact or likelihood; **-** = limited direct effect.

5. Conclusion and Future Scope

5.1 Why proactive cybersecurity matters

Across the case studies, attackers rarely relied on advanced “movie-style” hacking. They exploited trust (Arup), a missing MFA prompt (Change Healthcare and Snowflake's customers), neglected devices (Raptor Train) and the delay between a flaw becoming known and being patched (Ivanti and SharePoint). Basic, well-understood controls such as MFA, timely patching, segmentation, tested backups and trained staff would have prevented or limited the damage in most of these incidents.

Prevention is also cheaper than reaction. IBM puts the average breach at US$4.99 million globally and US$11.5 million in the US [3][4], and UnitedHealth reported about US$1.1 billion in costs from a single incident in one quarter [11].

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- Most breaches start with people, identities or unpatched systems, not exotic tools.
- MFA appeared as the missing control in two of the five case studies.
- Attackers are using AI and automation, so defenders must as well.
- Layered defense, tested regularly, limits the damage when something does go wrong.

5.2 Future scope

- **AI on both sides.** About one in four malicious breaches was AI-enabled in IBM's 2026 data, with an average cost near US$6 million. Yet organizations that used security AI and automation extensively cut breach costs by US$1.93 million and shortened the breach lifecycle by 65 days [3][4].

- **Shrinking patch windows.** Because exploitation now outpaces patching, automated asset discovery, attack-surface management and rapid virtual patching will matter more.
- **Deepfake-resistant verification.** Call-back procedures, shared code words and content-provenance tools will become standard for payments and sensitive requests.
- **Identity as the new perimeter.** Passkeys and phishing-resistant MFA are replacing passwords as the main defense for accounts.
- **Post-quantum cryptography.** NIST published its first post-quantum encryption standards in 2024, and organizations should begin inventorying where they use cryptography.

5.3 The need for continuous learning

Threats evolve faster than any report can capture, and this one reflects public information up to November 2026. Staying current means following CISA alerts and its KEV catalog, KrebsOnSecurity, vendor threat research and annual reports (Verizon DBIR, IBM Cost of a Data Breach, FBI IC3, ENISA Threat Landscape), practicing in hands-on labs and working toward recognized certifications. Cybersecurity is not a one-time project but a habit of constant learning, testing and improvement.

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Recommended further reading

OWASP (web application security): owasp.org | CISA Known Exploited Vulnerabilities catalog: cisa.gov/known-exploited-vulnerabilities-catalog | ENISA Threat Landscape: enisa.europa.eu | KrebsOnSecurity: krebsonsecurity.com